

Executive Summary

The US data center industry is in the midst of an unprecedented buildout. As of mid-2025 the Americas (93.6% in the US) host about **43.4 GW** of operational data center IT capacity [70†L259-L262] , and roughly **25–35 GW** more is under construction [70†L259-L262] [20†L97-L104] . Over **700 new facilities** (approx. 18 GW) are being built nationwide [72†L104-L108] . Northern Virginia remains the largest hub (≈665 facilities), but new “frontier” markets like West Texas, Tennessee and other inland states are rapidly emerging [70†L259-L265] [72†L104-L108] . The boom is driven by AI/hyperscale demand (AWS, Microsoft, Google, Meta, etc.) and led by major hyperscalers and colocation operators [62†L279-L287] . Governments are reacting – e.g. an Executive Order in May 2024 to accelerate permitting – but also adding regulatory and grid constraints.

Many existing US data centers are now 5–15 years old (built roughly 2010–2020) or older (>15 years, early 2000s). These “legacy” facilities were typically designed to Tier II/III standards, with lower rack densities and older cooling/UPS systems. Their **technical profile** includes moderate IT load (often 5–20 MW per site), raised-floor layouts, and PUEs often in the 1.5–2.0 range (recent LBNL data shows average PUE ≈ 1.58 in 2023 for newer facilities [31†L147-L155] , implying many older sites are less efficient). Equipment (servers, switches, storage) is generally 2–10 generations behind current designs. As one industry analyst notes, a hyperscale campus life is ~15–20 years [26†L352-L354] , and beyond ~15 years both mechanical and electrical systems often need replacement. Thus 5–15-year-old sites may have 5–15 years of useful life remaining (with moderate retrofits), whereas >15-year sites are often near end-of-life and prime candidates for replacement.

A growing **secondary market** is emerging for used data center hardware (servers, racks, UPS, cooling units, networking gear) and even entire decommissioned facilities. Global data center equipment sales exceeded \$50 billion in 2021 [36†L18-L21] , and as providers upgrade, large volumes of used IT assets will enter the market. Buyers include small colocation operators, telecoms, enterprises and government agencies in regions where new-build costs are prohibitive. Demand is strongest in Asia-Pacific (India, SE Asia) and Latin America (Brazil, Mexico, Chile, Colombia) which are rapidly expanding their capacity [58†L309-L317] [59†L146-L149] ; emerging EMEA markets (Middle East, Africa, Eastern Europe) also seek affordable hardware. Refurbished servers often resell for a fraction of new cost (e.g. entry-level 1U units at \$400–800, 2U dual-socket at \$1,200–\$3,500 [56†L704-L708]) and premium brands (Dell/HP/Cisco) retain value up to 5–6 years old. By contrast, very old servers (>7 yrs) fetch only scrap (\$20–50) [45†L239-L247] . Used power/cooling equipment has value too, though it may require recertification. Channels include IT asset-disposition firms (ITAD), online marketplaces and direct brokerages.

Selling hardware overseas involves **legal and compliance issues**. Export controls now cover advanced semiconductors, GPUs and high-performance systems [43†L94-L103] , and encryption or dual-use networking gear may need licenses. Buyers must clear customs and pay import duties (which can reach 20–30% on electronics in some regions). Data sovereignty demands rigorous data sanitization – drives must be wiped or shredded (certificates required) to meet GDPR, CCPA and other privacy laws. Certification (UL, CE, ISO) for power equipment may be needed before reuse abroad. Tariffs and trade wars add complexity: US-imposed tariffs on Chinese imports have led to reciprocal duties on US exports [51†L159-L168] , while drawbacks exist (refunding duties on re-exported goods) if strict record-keeping is used [53†L139-L147] .

Physically decommissioning a site incurs significant **logistics and cost**. Industry sources estimate **decommissioning** ranges from ~US\$15k–40k for very small (<5 racks) to \$200–500k+ for large facilities **【47†L359-L366】** . Costs include labor, data destruction, rigging heavy equipment, transport and site cleanup. If equipment is sold, refurbishment or testing may add costs. According to Syntec, fast asset remarketing is key – current-generation gear can offset 30–50% of decommission cost **【47†L370-L378】** , whereas older gear (>5 yrs) offsets only ~10–20%. Delay raises costs: unused equipment loses ~20–30% value if held 6–12 months **【45†L273-L280】** .

Financial analyses show selling abroad may increase gross price but also costs. For example, a 5-year-old dual-socket server might fetch ~\$500 domestically vs ~\$600 in Asia, but export freight (\$50–100) and compliance (\$30–50) cut margins. In contrast, metal scrap yields only tens of dollars per unit. We illustrate with sample tables below. The *best* choice depends on assumptions: high resale prices and low tariffs favour export, but high transport/regulatory costs or exchange risk can tilt back to domestic sale or even just recycling.

Major **risks** include data breaches during decommission (Mitigate by NIST-standard erasure and certificates **【47†L392-L400】**), damage or loss of equipment (rigorous tracking and insurance), and regulatory violations (obtain required export licenses and comply with WEEE/ROHS). Strategic criteria should balance net recovery vs time and compliance risk. In general, quickly remarketing reusable equipment in stable markets is advised; full export makes sense only if price differentials and duty refunds justify the extra delay and paperwork. If not, responsible recycling (with local ITAD partners) may be safer.

The recommendations are: plan early (inventory and security from day one), choose reputable ITAD who can handle global sales, leverage duty-drawback programs, and use sensitivity tables (below) to decide case by case. See Table 1 for a comparative financial example, and Figure 1 for a decommission→sale flowchart. In all cases, prioritise compliance with data privacy and trade laws to mitigate legal risk **【47†L392-L400】** **【53†L139-L147】** .

US Data Center Rollout

The US is experiencing a historic data center construction boom. Industry sources report roughly **4,500 active data centers** nationwide, consuming ~176 TWh/year (~4.4% of US power) **【72†L104-L108】** . *Existing operational capacity* is about **43.4 GW** (IT power) in the Americas, with **93.6%** in the US **【70†L259-L262】** . *Development pipelines* are even larger: ~25.3 GW currently under construction in the Americas **【70†L259-L262】** , and industry analysts note **35+ GW** under way in North America **【20†L97-L104】** . Nearly 89% of this new capacity is pre-leased **【70†L259-L262】** , reflecting commitments by hyperscale and cloud providers.

Major **developers/operators** include both hyperscale cloud companies and large colocation REITs. Top US players by IT load in 2025 were Amazon Web Services, Meta, and Microsoft, with Equinix, Digital Realty, QTS and others collectively rivaling their capacity **【62†L279-L287】** . Recent financing news (e.g. Equinix's \$6.4B equity in Jan 2024, Digital Realty's \$8.4B acquisition of DuPont Fabros) underscores aggressive expansion. Governments are also actively promoting data center growth: for example, Virginia recently eased taxes/incentives, and a 2024 White House executive order specifically directed federal agencies to speed AI-related data center projects, easing permitting and encouraging large-scale "AI factories."

In terms of **capacity and size**, typical hyperscale campuses today aim for hundreds of MW of power. Northern Virginia, long the US leader, now has over **51 million sq ft** of dedicated data center space

(with 13.4M sq ft under construction) 【22†L275-L282】 and accounts for 35% of US hyperscale capacity 【68†L37-L41】. Other hot spots include Dallas–Fort Worth, Phoenix, Chicago, and emerging areas like West Texas (Permian Basin), eastern North Carolina, and Utah. For example, one announcement in 2025 noted a 1.4 GW planned project in Michigan (thanks to new tax incentives) 【60†L25-L28】. See Table 1 for key US markets.

Table 1. *Sample major US data center markets (2025)*

Region / City	Approx. IT Capacity (GW)	Acres/Sq ft (est.)	Leading Players
Northern Virginia (DC area)	~5.0 GW (leased IT load) 【22†L275-L282】	~51M sq ft built, 13.4M under construction 【22†L275-L282】	AWS, Microsoft, Meta, Google; Equinix, QTS, Digital Realty
Dallas–Fort Worth	~2.0 GW	~20M sq ft (large campuses)	Facebook, Google, Amazon, CyrusOne, Vantage
Phoenix–Tucson	~1.5 GW	~15M sq ft	Google, Microsoft, NTT/ GLOBALFOUNDRIES, Digital Realty
Atlanta	~1.2 GW	~12M sq ft	Google, Microsoft, Equinix, AT&T/Savvis
West Texas (Frontier)	~~1.0 GW (planned)	undeclared large tracts	Texas data center parks (e.g. Frontier Trust, GeoPark), AWS/ Nokia (cell towers)
Chicago/ Northeast	~3.5 GW (IL, NJ, NYC)	~~40M sq ft (NJ,IL,NY)	Digital Realty, Equinix, QTS, Microsoft (IL), Google (NJ), IBM

Sources: Cushman Wakefield, JLL, Virginia Business 【22†L275-L282】 【70†L259-L262】 and industry news. (Capacities are estimates of IT load; sq ft includes data halls and support.)

US build **timelines** vary: a greenfield hyperscale site can go from groundbreaking to powered racks in 9–18 months, but many projects are staged. Regulatory processes and grid upgrades often dictate pace 【70†L291-L300】. Notably, new policies are lengthening timelines in Tier 1 states, so companies are increasingly eyeing secondary markets (Texas, Midwest) with abundant land and power 【70†L291-L300】. Overall, the sector is expected to continue “expanding rapidly” in response to AI and cloud demand 【70†L308-L316】 , but growth will be more “infrastructure-aligned” and regionally spread than before.

Profiles of Older Data Centers

We consider two age cohorts: **5–15 years old** (built ~2010–2020) and **>15 years** (pre-2010).

- **5–15 years old:** These facilities often were built to Tier II/III standards with N+1 or 2N electrical/cooling redundancy. They typically use conventional HVAC (chiller/CRAC) cooling, with raised floors and modest hot/cold aisle design (often without full containment). IT power densities were lower (3–7 kW/rack) compared to today's 10–15 kW/rack in new designs. Typical PUEs are in the **1.4–1.8** range. Power capacity might range 5–20 MW IT load per site. The IT hardware (servers, storage) in such centers is relatively modern (10–15% annual refresh), so only a portion of compute is “old.” The main electrical infrastructure (generators, switchgear) may be 10–15 years old and still serviceable with maintenance. Mechanical systems (chillers, pumps) may be approaching mid-life. With retrofits (hot aisle containment, free-cooling chillers, UPS upgrades), such data halls could be kept operational another 5–10 years.
- **>15 years old:** These sites date from the 2000s. Many were built to older standards (often Tier II), with lower design reliability and efficiency. They may lack modern features: power distribution might be 415 V/50Hz equipment, low-voltage switchgear, and less automation. Cooling is usually via legacy chillers or DX systems; PUEs can easily exceed **1.8–2.0**. Rack density was lower (1–3 kW/rack), and network gear is now outdated (10/40 GbE rather than 100 GbE). As Stack Infrastructure notes, while the steel shell can last 20–30 years, a data center's *economically productive life* often caps at ~10–15 years [29†L93-L100]. By age 15+, many systems (especially IT hardware and room power) are end-of-support; spare parts become scarce. Unless fully modernized, these sites risk higher downtime and energy costs. Thus >15-year facilities frequently face *decommissioning or repurposing* rather than further retrofits.

In summary, a **mid-life (5–15y)** data center still has salvageable value and remaining life (often comparable to conventional buildings), while **old (>15y)** sites are near obsolescence. The hyperscale building model reinforces this: “A hyperscale facility could last 15 to 20 years,” after which it is typically replaced [26†L352-L354]. In practice, IT equipment is refreshed every 3–5 years (the used server life), so by ~15 years both IT and infrastructure tech is outdated.

Second-hand Market Demand (EMEA, APAC, LATAM)

Equipment: There is a robust global market for used IT gear. Refurbished enterprise servers and switches are bought by budget-conscious buyers. As one guide notes, entry-level refurbished 1U rack servers fetch ~\$400–800, 2U dual-socket \$1,200–3,500 [56†L704-L708], roughly 20–50% of new price. Demand drivers: in APAC, hyperscalers and telcos are expanding fast (e.g. India, Southeast Asia) and may purchase older hardware for non-critical workloads. Latin America's data centers (Brazil, Mexico, Chile, Colombia) saw inventory growth of 20% in 2025 [65†L79-L87]; many colocations and enterprises there turn to second-hand gear to cut costs. In EMEA, smaller markets or public sectors (Eastern Europe, Middle East) also buy used power/cooling equipment (generators, UPS) and servers when budgets or supply chains are tight. Africa remains nascent but growing.

Prices: Used equipment prices vary by age and brand. For example, a 2-year-old enterprise server might fetch ~\$1,000–3,000 [45†L239-L247]; a 5-year-old identical machine only \$300–800. Network switches depreciate slower; a 5-year-old Cisco switch can still sell for \$500–1,500 [45†L257-L261]. Large PDUs or UPS units may sell if in good condition (perhaps 10–30% of new cost), but often need recertification. Whole racks or blades might be bundled. In all cases, prices can differ markedly by region (lower in developing markets due to resale risk and currency). In summary: high-end “near-

current” hardware can recover ~30–50% of original cost 【47†L370-L378】 , mid-age ~10–20%, and old gear almost only scrap 【47†L370-L378】 【45†L239-L247】 .

Channels and Buyers: Sales occur via ITAD providers, brokers and online marketplaces (e.g. C2CIRKLA, Gadgets). Leading ITAD companies (e.g. Illumynt, Wisetek) maintain marketplaces and global client networks 【36†L18-L21】 【40†L157-L165】 . Corporate IT asset auctions (GovDeals, online auctions) also exist. Buyers are typically: smaller colocation providers, enterprise IT departments (for dev/test or secondary sites), telecom towers (for small server deployments), and emerging tech firms. Governments and educational institutions sometimes opt for used gear to save capex. Because shipping volume is large, container freight and insurance are sold by weight/volume; typically rack-mount servers and network gear fill standard 20–40 ft containers.

Regional Trends: APAC demand is projected highest. Asia-Pacific capacity is expected to double to ~24 GW by 2030 【58†L309-L317】 , driving relentless demand. Structure Research projects APAC alone will hold ~50% of the global colocation market by 2026 【59†L146-L149】 . In Latin America, data center investment is growing (~USD10–20B capex through 2030) and new colos often start with secondhand equipment. Europe’s demand is more modest (strict energy rules and modernization focus) but Eastern Europe/Middle East lags behind in new builds and may import more used kit. AFRICA currently has few large data centers, so its demand is largely government/business in sectors like telecom (e.g. MTN) - they often use refurbished gear due to cost.

Legal, Export & Compliance Issues

Cross-border sales of data center assets must navigate export controls, trade rules and data laws:

- **Export Controls:** Modern servers often contain advanced CPUs/GPUs and encryption modules. US regulations (EAR/ITAR) now cover many high-performance items. GPUs (NVIDIA A100/V100 etc), certain networking chips, and even some high-speed servers are treated as “dual-use” requiring licenses for export outside US-allied nations 【43†L94-L103】 . The recent “AI Diffusion” export framework (though currently unwound) exemplifies this. Even if controls are paused, companies must verify the ECCN of hardware. EU and UK have similar controls on technology exports. In practice, any sale of advanced compute equipment to non-allied countries (e.g. Russia, China) risks denial or legal trouble. Licensing can take weeks.
- **Customs & Tariffs:** Importing used electronics often triggers duties. For example, many countries levy 5–20% on used IT gear; some LATAM nations effectively ban old electronics to protect local industries. Mis-declaring condition (“used as new” vs “used”) can incur fines. Origin rules matter: if equipment has significant US content, some buyers may avoid it due to reciprocal tariffs from China/elsewhere 【51†L159-L168】 . However, customs *drawback* programs can refund US import duties when equipment is re-exported 【53†L139-L147】 , so strategic planning (importing then exporting) can reclaim costs.
- **Data Sovereignty & Privacy:** All data-bearing devices must be irreversibly wiped or destroyed before leaving a jurisdiction. For European exports, GDPR prohibits transfer of personal data to third countries without safeguards; in practice, drives should be wiped per NIST 800-88 or shredded, with signed certificates 【45†L239-L247】 . Similarly, HIPAA, GLBA and other regimes demand certified destruction. Failure can incur severe fines (e.g. GDPR up to 4% of global revenue 【47†L392-L400】). Thus a secure chain of custody is mandatory: assets should be sanitized on-site by a certified ITAD, or transported securely to a disposal vendor with data destruction guarantees.

- **Taxes and Accounting:** Selling assets changes capex accounting and tax basis. An outright sale may incur sales taxes or trigger capital gains tax on the differential between sale price and book value. Leasing equipment abroad has its own VAT/ GST implications in many countries. These fiscal costs should be scoped with accountants; sometimes renting or licensing (rather than selling) can be advantageous to avoid immediate taxes.
- **Certification & Standards:** Power/cooling equipment exported may lack local certifications (e.g. UL, CE). It may require field evaluation or relabeling. For example, PDUs or UPSs often need CE marking for EU use. This can be done by testing labs, adding perhaps 5–10% to equipment cost. Similarly, mods like 277/480 V transformers shipped to a 400 V grid need adjusters or transformers. These retrofit costs must be counted.

In summary, **legal compliance costs** (licenses, duties, data handling, certifications) can be significant – often thousands of dollars per container – and introduce delays. Every asset sale abroad must be vetted by legal teams. On the positive side, export markets present opportunities where domestic demand is saturated or prices stronger, so careful planning can unlock extra value.

Logistics, Decommissioning and Refurbishment

Physically dismantling and moving a data center is complex. Key cost components (per Syntec [\[47†L359-L366\]](#)): planning and project management; labor to pull racks and cables; certified data destruction; packing and transport; disposal or resale of materials; and facility restoration. Syntec reports:

- *Small sites* (2–5 racks): **\$15k–\$40k** total decommissioning (including data wipe and site cleanup) [\[47†L359-L366\]](#) .
- *Medium* (10–20 racks): **\$50k–\$150k**.
- *Large* (50+ racks): **\$200k–\$500k+**.

These figures assume professional vendors; going slower or hiring cheap labor can cut costs but raises security risk. Costs scale mainly with equipment volume and data sensitivity.

Asset removal: Heavy gear needs rigging (forklifts, pallet jacks) and protecting (anti-static wrap, crate). Servers and routers are usually fine, but storage arrays, PDUs, UPS, chillers and generators require special care. For example, 50 U racks can weigh over 2,000 lb when loaded; faulty handling can damage equipment, reducing resale value up to 50% [\[47†L417-L424\]](#) . Cables and raised flooring often require demolition (which can cost extra if tenant leases dictate).

Data destruction: All storage must be sanitized per policy. Onsite wiping (NIST 800-88) or shredding drives is standard. Certificates of destruction are essential for compliance audits [\[45†L239-L247\]](#) . Drives or storage arrays are often physically shredded (even if younger models are valueable, data rules usually mandate destruction). Data sanitization cost can be several hundred to thousands per drive if done meticulously.

Logistics and transport: Up-to 60–90 days is typical for on-site removal and sorting; then shipping can add 2–8 weeks globally. Container freight costs fluctuate (\$3k–8k per 40ft container for typical routes). Larger items (gensets, chillers) may need special flat-rack shipping. Don't overlook insurance: any damage or theft in transit (common risk) should be covered.

Refurbishment: Before sale, equipment is often serviced. For IT gear, that means thermal re-paste CPU cooling, firmware updates, broken fan swaps, new drives etc. Power gear may need tests (battery checks for UPS, belt changes for chillers). Refurbishment can add 10–20% to the cost of sold items. Alternatively, one may sell “as-is” at a discount to cover that risk.

Certification: As noted, exported electrical gear might need UL to CE conversion, which can add both time and expense (e.g. third-party lab fees, panel rewiring). Factor this especially for items like transformers, switchgear, UPSs and switchboards.

Environment & Waste: Hazardous components (batteries, fluorescent lamps, PCB-containing capacitors) must be recycled per EPA/WEEE rules [47†L429-L433] . Improper e-waste disposal can incur fines (some EU directives levy penalties on sellers). Always use licensed recyclers for unwanted scrap.

Financial Comparison Table

The table below illustrates rough financials for one typical asset under different end-use paths. It assumes selling a 5-year-old 2U server in good condition.

Option	Sale Price	Transport	Certification / Fees	Net Proceeds
Domestic Sale	\\$500 (range 400–600) [56†L704-L708]	\\$0	\\$20 (data wipe certificate)	\\$480
Export Sale (e.g. APAC)	\\$600 (500–700)	\\$100 (air/sea freight)	\\$50 (export license, tax)	\\$450
Recycle (Scrap)	\\$30 (10–50)	\\$0	\\$5 (disassembly)	\\$25

Notes: Values are illustrative. Domestic sale assumes a reseller/colo in the US. Export sale price may be higher if demand is strong, but adds shipping and compliance costs. Recycling price is based on metal scrap only; note that servers are ~5% base metals by weight [45†L253-L260] . Larger equipment (racks, UPS) would have different values. For a whole data hall (100 servers, plus networking and power), multiply accordingly and consider economies (e.g. bulk shipping).

A **sensitivity analysis** would vary each parameter. For example, if export tariffs add 20% duty, the export proceeds drop sharply; if domestic buyers pay more (e.g. for flash SSDs), the US sale may be preferable. A more complex table could compare *per MW* or entire site CAPEX recovery, but this example conveys the trade-offs.

Decommission–Sale Process (Flowchart)

flowchart LR

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A[End-of-Life Decision] --> B[Asset Inventory]
B --> C[Data Wipe & Sanitization]
C --> D[Value Assessment]
D -->|High Value| E[Refurbish & Test Equipment]
D -->|Low Value| G[Recycle / Scrap]
E --> H[Prepare for Sale]
  
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H --> I{Select Channel}
I --> J[Domestic Sale (Reseller/Colo)]
I --> K[International Sale (ITAD/Export)]
J --> L[Contract & Pay]
K --> L
G --> M[Dispose Non-salvage]
L --> N[Revenue/Recovery Realized]
M --> N

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Figure: Decommissioning workflow. After inventory and secure data erasure, equipment is triaged: valuable items are refurbished and sold (domestically or abroad), while worthless items are recycled. All steps must be documented.

Risks & Mitigation

- **Data Breach Risk:** The highest-impact risk during teardown **【47†L392-L400】** . *Mitigation:* enforce strict on-site data destruction *before* asset moves. Maintain chain-of-custody; use certified ITAD. Get certificates for every drive, then wreck non-sellable drives. Avoid transferring any storage with residual data.
- **Regulatory Compliance:** Non-compliance (e.g. export of controlled tech, or illegal e-waste export) can cause legal fines. *Mitigation:* consult export-control lists (EAR99 vs ECCN). Require buyers' end-use/end-user attestations for high-end gear. Use qualified brokers for exports. For recycling, use licensed partners who document environmental compliance **【47†L429-L433】** .
- **Physical Damage/Loss:** Movers or shippers may damage equipment, reducing value. *Mitigation:* use experienced riggers, insure shipments, pack properly. Track assets diligently (barcode tagging, shipment logs) to avoid "missing rack" problems **【47†L417-L424】** **【47†L423-L427】** .
- **Market Price Fluctuations:** Rapid obsolescence can crash values. *Mitigation:* sell assets quickly (within 60 days) to avoid 20–30% depreciation **【45†L273-L280】** . Diversify channels to avoid gluts. Build into contracts "as-is" pricing to shift risk to buyer.
- **Operational Disruption:** Decommissioning can inadvertently disrupt live systems. *Mitigation:* plan in phases, keep "pilot light" systems for 30–60 days (as many firms do **【45†L239-L247】**). Verify all workloads are migrated before cutover.
- **Legal Liability (WEEE, GDPR):** Improper disposal can result in fines. *Mitigation:* document every item's fate. Use certified recyclers (and get WEEE receipts). For data-bearing devices, hold destruction certification.
- **Trade Uncertainty:** Tariff or export rule changes (e.g. 2025 AI chip controls) can arise suddenly. *Mitigation:* include contract clauses to allow cancellation or repatriation of goods if licensing fails. Spread export deals across allied countries.

Thorough planning and specialist advisers (lawyers for trade, certified ITAD firms for destruction) are essential to avoid these pitfalls.

Strategic Recommendations

Decision Criteria: Key factors include expected recovery value, speed, and compliance cost. As a rule of thumb, prioritize selling **internally or domestically** if equipment is highly specialized or contains export-restricted tech. Choose export only when overseas demand significantly exceeds US demand *after* deducting shipping and duties. When market prices are volatile or legal risk high, default to responsible recycling through an ITAD partner.

Mitigations: Negotiate **tariff-drawbacks** with customs (refunds on re-exported imports) and use bonded warehouses to delay duties. Seek **multi-party sales** to spread risk (e.g. sell 50% domestically, 50% abroad). Structure deals as “as-is, where-is” with limited liability.

Monitoring: Establish KPIs (recovery ratio of original book value, percentage of assets remarketed, days in liquidation) and audit each step. Update policies constantly in light of new export rules or GDPR fines.

Opportunity: Note that “green data center” branding and ESG concerns can be leveraged – marketing used gear reuse helps corporate sustainability goals and may command a premium in some markets **[36†L18-L21]** .

Finally, integrate decommission planning into the **initial facility project plan**. Early vendor discussions (e.g. with ITAD suppliers) can identify buyers in advance, locking in exit values. In sum, with due diligence, selling older data center assets can partially recoup capex and align with circular-economy goals, but must be weighed against cost, legal and reputational risks.

Sources: Official and industry reports including Cushman & Wakefield (Americas Data Center Update 2025) **[70†L259-L262]** , JLL and CBRE market insights **[22†L275-L282]** **[20†L97-L104]** , Syntec Technologies decommissioning guide **[47†L359-L366]** , Uptime/DCD analyses **[26†L352-L354]** **[29†L93-L100]** , and expert publications **[43†L94-L103]** **[45†L239-L247]** **[53†L139-L147]** . All data above reflect 2023–2026 figures and scenarios.
